

Awareness and attitudes toward digital work platforms among Albanian students



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Abstract In recent years, digital labor platforms have significantly transformed the landscape of work opportunities across the globe. Prominent examples of these platforms include Glovo, Wolt, Fiverr, and Upwork, each offering a unique interface for connecting workers with a variety of tasks and projects. However, in countries such as Albania, whose economy is still developing, knowledge and engagement with such platforms remain limited, particularly among younger populations. This study presents the results of a structured survey conducted with 200 students from the Faculty of Law, University of Tirana, aiming to assess their awareness of digital labor platforms and their legal implications. The findings reveal a striking lack of knowledge; 90% of respondents stated that they have no information about how digital labour platforms operate or about the rights and obligations of workers engaged in such forms of employment. Only a small minority, approximately 10%, even had a basic understanding of such forms of employment. These data raise significant concerns about the preparedness of the future workforce to participate in the platform economy and highlight the risk of digital exclusion. The article discusses these results within the broader context of European Union-level regulation, as Albania is a candidate for Union membership, and the emerging legal frameworks on algorithmic management and platform workers' rights. This study calls for urgent awareness campaigns, legal literacy programs, and the integration of platform economy topics into academic curricula to address this knowledge gap. By shedding light on the current state of awareness among students, this research contributes to the policy discourse on inclusive and fair digital transitions in labour markets.

Keywords: platform economy, labour law, technology, youth, employment

1. Introduction

Digital labor platforms have also undergone development in Albania, especially since the pandemic of COVID-2019. The greatest legal challenge that every individual engaged in digital platforms is still facing today is the lack of definition of the legal status that he has in this relationship. This challenge is followed by another challenge that is closely related to whether work on digital platforms is an employment relationship. The legal provisions that have built the employment relationship over the decades, both in doctrinal and practical terms, have taught us that being an employee is directly related to the employment contract. This principle was born from the Labour Code in every country in the world, which, if interpreted today in the context of work on digital platforms, will classify them as self-employed. In response to the evolving nature of work and the legal ambiguity surrounding digital labor platforms, institutional and legislative bodies at both the national and international levels have embarked on the crucial task of establishing normative frameworks to regulate platform-based work (Collier et al., 2017; De Stefano, 2016; Bauer et al., 2023; Lane, 2020; Stewart & Williams, 2023). A key priority in these efforts is the accurate classification of individuals performing platform work as employees rather than as independent contractors. Such classification is essential to ensure that these workers are afforded the full range of labour protection under employment law, including access to social security, collective bargaining rights, and fair working conditions.

The International Labour Organisation defined work in digital labour platforms as a non-standard form of employment, noting that it is often characterised by a lack of regular contracts, unclear employment status, and a lack of social and union protection (International Labour Organization, 2021). These characteristics place this form of work outside traditional employment relations schemes and create challenges for labour legislation and policies around the world. In its reports, the International Labour Organization (ILO) noted that although platform work offers flexibility and access to the global labour market, it also deepens employment insecurity, fragments labour relations, and complicates the protection of workers' rights, such as fair wages, social security, and collective bargaining (2018, 2021, 2022, 2024, 2025). Furthermore, the lack of a clear legal framework defining the relationship between the worker and the platform creates uncertainty in terms of legal protection. In many cases, platform workers are treated as self-employed, thus being excluded from the protection provided for traditional employees (Cherry, 2016; De Stefano, 2016; Pinsof, 2016; Prassl & Risak, 2016). This situation has prompted the International Labour Organization (ILO) and the European Commission (EC), among other international bodies, to call for clearer legal regulation and new approaches to guaranteeing workers' rights (2018, 2021; 2021). It is very important for respecting the principle of decent work and guaranteeing rights at work that every country today has a proper legal framework that protects



every individual who is engaged in digital work platforms. Given the legal challenges faced by the International Labour Organisation (ILO) and the European Union (EU) countries, Albania is in a difficult situation. First, there are no specific data on the exact number of platform workers in Albania, and according to labor legislation, this type of work is not recognised as a traditional employment relationship (Muskaj, 2025).

The findings from our recent survey of 200 students of the Faculty of Law show that nearly 90% are unaware of how digital labor platforms operate, whether this type of work is regulated by the Labour Code in Albania, and the rights of platform workers. This knowledge gap reflects the invisibility of the platform economy in Albanian policy and educational discourse and underscores the need for targeted awareness-raising initiatives, legal reforms, and academic engagement to bridge the divide between technological innovation and labour rights.

2. Literature Review

Digital labour platforms have become a defining feature of the contemporary labour market, reshaping traditional employment relationships and introducing new legal, social, and policy challenges. Rapid growth, particularly following the COVID-19 pandemic, has been accompanied by increasing academic and institutional attention, with a focus on the classification of platform workers, the impact of algorithmic management, and the adequacy of existing labour protections (Adams-Prassl & Gruber-Risak, 2019; Aloisi & De Stefano, 2022; Baiocco et al., 2022; De Stefano et al., 2021; De Stefano & Taes, 2022; Hießl, 2021; OECD, 2020, 2023; Rani et al., 2024; Wood, 2021). The International Labour Organisation (ILO) has consistently defined platform work as a form of nonstandard employment, often characterised by the absence of formal contracts, unclear employment status, and insufficient social and union protections (ILO, 2018, 2021; Pulignano, 2025). Many recent studies highlight that while platform work offers flexibility and global market access, it also exacerbates employment insecurity, fragments labour relations, and complicates the enforcement of core rights such as fair wages, social protection and collective bargaining (Graham & Wood, 2016; Graham et al., 2017; Irani, 2015; Kässi & Lehdonvirta, 2018; Lehdonvirta, 2016; Parker et al., 2016; World Bank, 2016). Within the European context, the adoption of Directive (EU) 2024/2831 marks a significant step towards harmonising legal standards for platform work, particularly by introducing measures for algorithmic transparency, mandating proper employment status determination, and strengthening enforcement mechanisms (Directive (EU) 2024/2831). At the regional level, empirical studies on the Western Balkans remain limited but provide important insights. Eurofound's research on youth employment in the Western Balkans highlights a growing prevalence of nonstandard work arrangements but a notable lack of targeted education and awareness-raising initiatives regarding platform work among young people (Eurofound, 2022). According to Albania, the literature is notably scarce but growing. The Fairwork Albania Ratings 2023 assessed five major platforms, Baboon, SpeedTaxi, Aladini, MerrJep, and Tregu, against Fairwork's five principles, revealing significant disparities in fair pay and contract clarity (Fairwork, 2023a). The European Training Foundation's country report further identified structural challenges in integrating platform work in the informal economy, including gaps in digital skills, regulatory frameworks, and social protection systems (European Training Foundation, 2022). Another policy brief (Dionizi et al., 2023) examined the barriers faced by Albanian freelancers and gig workers, such as cross-border payment limitations, lack of legal recognition, and weak collective organisations. All the studies reveal a substantial research gap in understanding public awareness of platform work in Albania, particularly among university students, who represent a potential future workforce. Despite the increasing presence of platforms in the Albanian economy, there is little evidence on how young people perceive or understand these work arrangements, the role of algorithms in managing work, and the rights available to platform workers under international labour standards. The present study addresses this gap by combining a review of the global, European, and national literature with empirical evidence from a survey of 200 Albanian law students, offering a dual perspective on both regulatory frameworks and societal awareness.

3. Materials and Methods

3.1. Purpose

This research aims to assess the level of awareness among Albanian university students regarding digital labor platforms and their understanding of platform-based work.

3.2. Research question and hypothesis

The central research aims to answer the following question:

RQ: How aware are Albanian university students of the legal challenges and protections related to digital labor platform work?

To actualise and validate the data in this research, several hypotheses are outlined below:

H1. A majority of Albanian university students lack sufficient knowledge about digital labor platforms and the rights and obligations associated with platform-based work.

H2. University students in Albania are not adequately informed about the legal regulation of digital platform work in the country.

H3. Students perceive platform work as a male-dominated sector and are unclear about the employment status of platform workers.

3.3. *Methods and procedures*

The research employed a transversal and cross-sectional design with a mixed-methods approach. Quantitative data were collected through a structured questionnaire, while qualitative insights were obtained from observational notes and analysis of open-ended responses. Similar approaches have been widely used in recent research on digital platform work to capture both statistical patterns and contextual perceptions (Rani & Furrer, 2021; Wood et al., 2019).

The questionnaire consisted of three main sections: (1) demographic data, (2) knowledge and awareness of digital platforms, and (3) perceptions of gender, employment status, and fairness in platform work. Questions were primarily close-ended, using categorical or Likert-scale options, with a small number of open-ended items to capture individual perspectives. The survey was designed in Google Forms and distributed electronically to the target group. Informed consent was obtained from all participants at the start of the questionnaire.

Responses were exported into Excel for cleaning and organization. The data were analyzed using descriptive statistics (frequencies, percentages, cross-tabulations) to identify general trends. Qualitative responses and observational notes were coded thematically and integrated with the quantitative analysis (Meijerink & Bondarouk, 2023).

3.4. *Sample*

A total of 200 third-year law students from the Faculty of Law, University of Tirana, participated in the survey. The selection was deliberate: in the third year, students are exposed to the Albanian Labour Code, making them more likely to understand employment law principles.

The participants were aged 19–25 years, and none of them were forced to complete the questionnaire. Gender distribution was 75% female and 25% male, reflecting the demographic reality of the Faculty of Law. The homogeneity of the sample (law students only) was intentional, aimed at evaluating awareness among students who should, at least theoretically, have some familiarity with labor law.

3.5. *Demographic characteristics of the sample*

The study sample was relatively uniform in terms of field of study but diverse in age within the undergraduate cohort. Female students were the majority, which may reflect broader gender trends in law school enrollment in Albania. While the limited demographic scope restricts generalization, it provides a focused insight into the awareness levels of students most likely to engage with platform work from a legal perspective.

3.6. *Methodological limitations*

Several limitations of this study must be acknowledged in interpreting the findings. The sample was nonrandom because the study relied on a convenience sample from a single university, which limits the generalizability of the results. Additionally, participants were exclusively law students; this field restriction implies that these respondents may have a higher baseline awareness of the issues than students in other disciplines. Another limitation is the reliance on self-reported data, which could introduce biases such as recall bias or social desirability bias. Furthermore, the cross-sectional design of the research provides only a snapshot in time and does not track changes in participants' knowledge or perceptions over time. Despite these limitations, the study offers valuable preliminary evidence on the knowledge gaps and perceptions of digital labor platforms among future legal professionals in Albania.

4. **Results**

The following describes the level of familiarity 200 law students (Table 1) have with the concept of digital labor platforms, specifically with Wolt, Foodini, UpWork, Baboon, Patoko, and VrapOn. Some of the most common digital labor platforms in Tirana, the capital of Albania, are mentioned. We chose these platforms because we thought that the probability of these students having some knowledge about them would be high, but a significant majority of the respondents in Table 2 (95%) reported that they were not familiar with the concept of digital labor platforms in Albania. Only a small minority, 5%, reported being aware of digital labor platforms. This lack of awareness underscores a significant information gap regarding new forms of employment emerging in the gig economy, particularly among youth preparing for entry into the labour market. This lack of knowledge is a result of the lack of a legal framework that regulates nonstandard forms of employment in Albania. The Labour Code is the main law that regulates labour relations in Albania, the principles of which are based on the traditional form of labour relations. As a result, work on digital platforms based on the Labour Code is not a traditional labour relationship between the employee and the employer. For this reason, people who work on digital platforms are classified as self-employed.

Scientific research and reports on the development of digital platforms identify the lack of legislation and misclassification of employees engaged in digital platforms (Andjelković et al., 2024; Dionizi et al., 2023, 2024; Kasimati, 2022; Muskaj, 2025).

According to the data presented in Table 3, 86% of the surveyed students reported that they had never worked on a digital labor platform, whereas only 14% stated that they had such experience. These findings suggest a low level of direct engagement with platform work among law students, which may be attributed to limited awareness, legal gaps, or a lack of access to these forms of employment. In Albania, the age profile of platform workers varies by the nature of their employment. According to the European Training Foundation (ETF)'s Embracing the Digital Age report and Kasimati (2022), most remote platform workers fall within the 25–35 age group, whereas those in on-location services, such as delivery or ride-hailing, tend to be between 25–40 years old (European Training Foundation, 2022; Kasimati, 2022).

Table 4 below illustrates the responses of 200 law students to the following question: “Are you aware that digital platform work is legally regulated in labour legislation in Albania? The results show that 55% of law students believe that such work is not legally regulated, 35% think it is regulated, and 10% stated that it was their first time hearing about digital labor platforms. These data reflect a significant lack of awareness about the legal status of digital labor platforms among young adults in Albania.

According to the survey responses in Table 5, 58% of the students believe that male workers are more represented on digital labor platforms, whereas 42% believe that female workers are more represented. These findings suggest a prevailing perception that digital labor platforms in Albania are predominantly male dominated, possibly influenced by the types of jobs typically offered on such platforms, including delivery services and technical freelance work. According to the Fairwork Albania Ratings 2023, the gender distribution among platform workers is relatively balanced, with 55.8% identified as male and 44.2% as female (Fairwork, 2023). Another study by Kopliku et al. (2025) emphasised the importance of promoting gender equality and mitigating structural vulnerability, especially for women engaging in digital labour platforms. The on-location platform sector is male-dominated, whereas the share of women is higher in cloudwork than in other countries in the region (Gigmetar, 2023). UN Women (2023) reports that digitalisation and ICT underscore the gender skills gap, a key factor influencing participation in platform-based labour.

As shown in Table 6, the majority of the respondents (92%) expressed interest in receiving more information about digital platforms, whereas only 8% reported no interest. This indicates a strong demand for additional knowledge and awareness regarding the functioning and impact of digital platforms among participants.

Table 1 Demographic characteristics of the sample (N=200).

Variable	Number of Participants	Percentage (%)
Gender		
Female	150	75%
Male	50	25%
Age group		
19–25 years	200	100%
Year of Study		
Third Year (Bachelor)	200	100%
Marital Status		
Unmarried	200	100%

Table 2 Awareness of digital platform work.

Response Option	Number of Respondents	Percentage (%)
No, I have never worked on a platform	172	86%
Yes, I have worked on a platform	28	14%
Total	200	100%

Table 3 Familiarity with the digital platform work in Albania.

Question	Yes (%)	No (%)
Are you familiar with the concept of digital platform work in Albania?	5%	95%

Table 4 Knowledge of the legal regulation of digital platform work in Albania.

Response	Percentage
Yes, it is legally regulated	35%
No, it is not legally regulated	55%
This is the first time I hear about digital platforms	10%

Table 5 Gender in digital platform work in Albania.

Question	Response	Percentage
Which gender do you see most often represented in digital platform work?	Male	58%
	Female	42%

Table 6 Future interest about digital platforms.

Question	Response	Percentage
Are you interested in receiving more information about digital platforms?	Yes	92%
	No	8%
	Total	100%

5. Discussion

The findings of this study confirm the limited awareness of Albanian law students regarding digital labor platforms, consistent with prior work on the invisibility of the platform economy in emerging economies (Digital Future Society, 2019; Eurofound, 2022; Graham et al., 2017; ILO, 2021; Fairwork, 2023b). The fact that 92% of the respondents expressed interest in receiving more information indicates not only a lack of knowledge but also a strong demand for educational and awareness initiatives. This is consistent with studies that underline the need to improve legal literacy and digital skills among young people to ensure an inclusive transition toward the platform economy (Dionizi et al., 2024; Fairwork, 2023).

The perception that digital platform work is male dominated by 58% reflects structural barriers and cultural attitudes that influence gender participation in the digital labour market. Similar results have been reported in other Western Balkan contexts, where on-location services (delivery, transport) are predominantly male-dominated, whereas remote cloudwork shows greater female participation (Dhëmbo & Vrbaški, 2024; Eurofound, 2022; Fairwork, 2023a, 2023b; Kopliku et al., 2025; Rodríguez-Modroño et al., 2022).

From a legal perspective, more than half of the respondents (55%) believe that platform work is not regulated under Albanian labour legislation. This perception aligns with the current legal reality, as Albanian labour law does not yet recognise platform work as a traditional employment relationship. Comparative studies at the EU level show that without a clear classification of platform workers as employees, these workers remain excluded from key rights such as fair pay, social protection, and collective bargaining (Aloisi et al., 2023; De Stefano, 2015, 2016; Directive (EU) 2024/2831; Urzi Brancati et al., 2020). Therefore, the results of these studies underscore the urgency of aligning national labour legislation with EU standard and international instruments to guarantee decent work conditions for platform workers. Since Albania is a candidate country to become part of the European family, it has a greater responsibility to implement Directive (EU) 2024/2831 on improving working conditions in digital labor platforms in national legislation.

6. Final Considerations

This study has shown that Albanian law students have limited awareness of digital labor platforms and the legal challenges surrounding them. With 95% of the respondents unfamiliar with platform work and 55% believing that it is not legally regulated, the results highlighted both a lack of legal recognition and the invisibility of this form of employment in academic and policy debates. Moreover, the strong demand for more information expressed by 92% of the students reveals an urgent need for awareness campaigns, curriculum integration, and legal literacy initiatives to prepare the future workforce for the realities of the platform economy. Increasing awareness of work on digital platforms would also contribute to the recognition of the concept of algorithmic management and the resizing of work (Zhang et al., 2025)

The Albanian case illustrates the broader challenges faced by Western Balkan candidate countries, where platform work remains unregulated and workers are often misclassified as self-employed, leaving them outside the scope of basic labor protections. Therefore, aligning national legislation with the European Union's Directive (EU) 2024/2831 on platform work, particularly in terms of employment status determination, algorithmic transparency, and social protection, should be a priority. For Albania, this means not only adopting the EU standard but also ensuring that the next generation of professionals, who are today's students, are equipped with the knowledge and skills to navigate and shape a fair digital labour market. By bridging the gap between technological innovation and labour rights, Albania can both advance its EU integration path and secure more inclusive and decent working conditions for its youth.

Acknowledgment

The authors wish to express sincere gratitude to the students of the Faculty of Law, University of Tirana, who voluntarily participated in the survey and generously shared their time and perspectives. Their engagement made this research possible and provided essential data for the study.

Ethical Considerations

Ethical oversight. Under the University of Tirana policy for minimal-risk, anonymous survey research conducted in classroom settings, this study did not require formal review by an ethics/IRB committee. The authors affirm compliance with University of Tirana internal guidelines as well as applicable national and international ethical standards. Participants and procedures. Two hundred (200) University of Tirana (Faculty of Law) students completed an anonymous online survey on knowledge and perceptions of digital labour platforms. Participation was strictly voluntary, unrelated to assessment or course standing, and students were informed that they could choose to complete the questionnaire or not. Informed consent. Before beginning the questionnaire, students saw an information page describing the study's purpose, procedures, potential risks/benefits, confidentiality protections, and the voluntary nature of participation. Consent was indicated by proceeding to and submitting the survey. Students could decline to participate or stop at any time without penalty. Confidentiality and data protection. No personal identifiers (e.g., names, student IDs, emails) were collected. Responses were recorded anonymously and analysed in aggregate. Data are stored on a secure University of Tirana drive accessible only to the research team and will be retained for 12 months in line with University policy and applicable data-protection law, after which all datasets will be securely deleted. A de-identified summary of aggregate results may be retained for reporting and reproducibility. Clinical trial registration. Not applicable (no clinical interventions). Consent for publication. Not applicable; no identifiable personal details or images are published. Records of the consent procedure can be provided to the journal upon request.

Conflict of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Funding

This research did not receive any financial support.

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